The missing step: preparing the candidate

Brief for the meeting with Mukesh. Draft, 12 October 2026. Written by Francis Cobbinah, TheInterviewChair.com.

The idea in one sentence

Recruitment is built to find and submit the candidate. Nobody is equipped, or paid, to prepare them, yet the interview is the one moment that decides whether the recruiter earns anything.

The gap

- A recruiter spends days sourcing, screening and submitting. Then comes the interview, and the support is "Good luck on Thursday".
- Recruiters do brief candidates: the job spec, a call, some tips. **Briefing is not rehearsal.** Nobody can have twenty candidates say their answers out loud to a listener, and get scored, the night before.
- The cost of that gap lands on the recruiter. A candidate who fumbles the interview is a lost fee and weeks of work gone.

What TheInterviewChair does about it

- **Interview Prep (push).** The recruiter sends a link with the job spec and CV loaded. The candidate gets up to 3 practice interviews: spoken, scored on five dimensions, with feedback and a path to a pass.
- **The Magic Button (pull).** A "Practise for this job" button beside a job advert. One click puts the candidate into a practice interview for that exact job. Two demo versions exist: a job-board style page and a recruiter-branded careers page.
- **The result belongs to the candidate.** Scores, certificate and a shareable link, so every prep sent also brings a new person onto the platform.

Why it is possible now

- Personalised, spoken, scored practice for any job used to mean a human coach at £50 an hour or more. With AI it costs us about **2p to 3p** for a 3-question demo (measured) and an estimated **5p** for a full interview.
- A prep with up to 3 sessions therefore costs roughly 15p to deliver. At the published price of 99p that is about 85p gross margin per prep (estimates, to be firmed up with real usage).
- The recruiter has a direct reason to pay: one saved fee covers a very large number of preps.

The loop

1. Recruiter sends a prep.
2. Candidate practises and gets scored.
3. Candidate shares the result or certificate.
4. Employers can watch and find them.
5. Candidate gets the job and says so.
6. More recruiters and candidates arrive.

The size of it (rough)

- About **3.5 million** individual recruiters worldwide (a 2024 industry estimate extrapolated from LinkedIn data; treat as rough).
- UK: over **31,000** recruitment businesses and about **119,000** staff in the industry (REC, 2019, the latest figures I found).
- Illustration only: 1,000 recruiter seats at £49 a month is £49,000 a month. If each sends 20 preps a month at 99p, that adds about £19,800 a month.

What is built and live today

- Recruiter portal: send an interview prep, sent list, candidate search, talent alerts, client gifts, team feed and seat roster.
- Candidate side: received preps, live spoken interviews, five-dimension scoring, verdict and certificate, shareable results, Learn, Learn Alerts, mock exams, CV analysis, Careers Explorer, Career Coach, My Talks.
- Pricing live: candidate £4.99 a month, recruiter £49 a seat, employer £399 a month, payments through Stripe.
- Free demo with no account, in 32 languages, at about 2p to 3p each.

What is not proven yet (say this in the room)

- **Recruiter usage.** One pilot so far (Vallum Associates). No evidence yet of how many preps a recruiter will send.
- **Does it win offers?** We do not yet measure sent, opened, started, completed, second attempt and offer. That funnel is the first thing to build, and the first number a recruiter will ask for.
- **Per-prep billing.** 99p per prep is the published price. Billing it per prep is not built; recruiters pay through the seat fee today.
- **The Magic Button on other people's job pages.** Demos exist. A one-line embed, or a "practice link" generated per job that a recruiter pastes into an advert, is the next build.
- **What the big platforms do, and do not do.** LinkedIn Premium offers AI interview practice on job postings (for jobs where the member is a strong match), and Indeed has an AI mock-interview tool (Career Scout). Both are candidate-side and self-serve, and LinkedIn's is behind a paid subscription. I have not found any of them putting practice in the **recruiter's** hands to send, and none is free to the public beside every job. That is the gap. My first-hand evidence: in 25 years of interviewing and hiring, no recruiter has ever sent me practice questions, and Mike Petrie, 30 years in recruitment, has never seen it either.

What I would test in the next 30 days

- 10 recruiters, 20 preps each, over 30 days.
- Measure: prep opened, started, completed, second attempt, score change, interview to offer.
- Build per-job practice links so a recruiter can put one link on any advert.
- Send each recruiter a short report: who practised, how they scored, who got the offer.

One line for the pitch

Every recruiter sends "good luck". We let them send a rehearsal.